

Japan Technology: Semiconductors: Investor visit feedback: Expectations for front-end firms seem high, including for price hikes

Many investors were bullish on front-end equipment companies in particular within SPE

We held around 40 investor meetings in Hong Kong from July 6 to 10. Although the upward share price trend seen until June has changed somewhat, many investors generally maintained a bullish stance on the sustainability of AI demand and the semiconductor/SPE cycle. In terms of sub-sector preferences, we had the impression that many investors favored (1) front-end over back-end, (2) memory capex over non-memory capex, and (3) CPU-related over GPU/ASIC-related, with a large number of investors bullish on front-end equipment companies in particular (**Tokyo Electron (TEL)**, **SCREEN Holdings**, **Kokusai Electric**) due to expectations for WFE market expansion. On the other hand, we came away with the impression that there were not many bullish investors on back-end companies (**Disco**, **Advantest**) or on companies with relatively low memory exposure (**Lasertec**, **Ebara**). For **Kioxia Holdings**, while many investors saw the recent share price correction as a good opportunity to add to positions, our impression is that there were also quite a few concerns that earnings surprises are becoming less likely compared to before due to the lower rate of change in NAND prices.

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Many questions regarding equipment price hikes

Frequently asked questions from investors included (1) expectations for the WFE market, (2) the stance on price hikes at front-end equipment companies and their progress, and (3) the sustainability of memory price increases and views on the supply/demand balance. On the **WFE market**, our impression is that investor expectations are already around US\$200 bn for CY27 (our estimate is US\$187 bn), and expectations for sustainable growth from CY28 onward were also high, partly due to the recent announcements of new fabs by memory companies. As for the possibility of **equipment price hikes**, with TEL proactively pushing ahead with them, expectations also appear to be rising for the possibility of this spilling over to other companies. On **memory prices**, we got the sense that expectations for CY3Q (Jul-Sep) NAND prices are for an increase of c.+15-20% qoq, but there was also strong caution about the possibility of the rate of change gradually slowing going forward.

Prefer names whose earnings expectations could rise due to

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company-specific factors

We continue to focus on two key points for our individual stock recommendations: (1) whether a company can achieve sales growth above the sector average through technological change, proprietary technologies, or market share gains, and (2) whether top-line strength leads to a significant increase in profit margins. In the SPE sector, we highlight our Buy ratings on **LaserTec (on CL)**, **Ebara**, **Disco**, and **TEL**, and on **Kioxia Holdings** in memory.

Exhibit 1: Target prices, methodology, and risks for stocks mentioned

Company Name (rating)	Ticker	12-m TP (¥)	Methodology	Risks
DISCO (Buy)	6146.T	100,000	Based on the global SPE sector average multiple of 18X and our FY3/28E estimates. We then apply a sector-relative premium of 50%.	(-) slowdown or share loss in AI-related demand (-) slowdown in China demand or tightening of export controls (-) rapid yen appreciation against the USD
Ebara (Buy)	6361.T	7,800	Based on the correlation between P/B and our FY12/27E ROE estimates.	(-) Semiconductor capex enters a downcycle (-) Increasing competitiveness of Chinese CMP system makers (-) Slow adoption of new technology in semiconductor devices (-) Decline in crude oil/LNG prices, oil refining/petrochemical margins
Kokusai Electric (Neutral)	6525.T	9,500	Based on the global SPE sector average multiple of 18X and our FY3/28E estimates.	(+/-) Changes in investment at key customers (+/-) Additional changes in export controls (+/-) Changes in the competitive landscape due to strategic changes at competitors
Advantest (Neutral)	6857.T	34,000	Based on the global SPE sector average multiple of 18X and our FY3/28E estimates. We then apply a sector-relative premium of 40%.	(+/-) fluctuations in customer capex appetite (+/-) fluctuations in market share (+/-) trends in tester demand for China (+/-) FX fluctuations for JPY/USD
LaserTec (Buy)*	6920.T	67,000	Based on the global SPE sector average multiple of 18X and the average of our FY6/28E estimates. We then apply a sector-relative premium of 50%.	(-) Decline in market share due to new entrants (-) Lack of progress in ACTIS adoption by wafer fabs (-) Weaker customer investment appetite for leading-edge process nodes (-) Rapid appreciation of the yen against the US dollar
SCREEN HD (Sell)	7735.T	12,500	Based on the global SPE sector average multiple of 18X and our FY3/28E estimates, to which we apply a sector-relative discount of 40%.	(+) higher profit margins in the SPE business (+) market share gains due to company-specific factors (+) enhancement of shareholder returns (+) a market shift in favor of value stocks
Tokyo Electron (Buy)	8035.T	83,000	Based on the global SPE sector average multiple of 18X and our FY3/28E estimates. We then apply a sector-relative premium of 30%.	(-) prolonged inventory adjustment phase in the semiconductor industry (-) further strengthening of export restrictions (-) depressed valuation multiple amid upward pressure on interest rates and other factors
Kioxia HD (Buy)	285A.T	116,000	Based on the correlation between P/B and our FY3/27-3/28E ROE estimates.	(-) A slowdown in AI investment centered on hyperscalers (-) Rise of NAND players in China (-) Decline in profit margins due to cost increases or fluctuations in capacity utilization (-) A sharp appreciation of the yen against the US dollar

*Stock is on the APAC conviction list

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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